

A Short Story: The Golden Nugget [B1]

A volte, la vita ci sorprende con rivelazioni inattese che cambiano il modo in cui vediamo le cose. Questa è la storia di una famiglia e di un'eredità nascosta.

Come on in," said Ricardo, as his two sons arrived at his modest home in Los Angeles, California. He had invited them there for a family reunion. It would be their final family reunion, and perhaps the most important one they'd ever had. At first, his son Carlos had refused to come, but then Ricardo had sent him a photo of the golden nugget that was now at the center of the room, accompanied by the message "It's real." Carlos and his brother, Felipe, stared at the nugget. "It can't be real," said Carlos. "It can't be." "It certainly is real," said Ricardo. "Your great-great-great-great-grandfather could attest to that. He almost broke his back while transporting it home from the Sierra Nevada mountains. I'll never understand how he kept it a secret. But he did. He kept it secret from everybody but his heirs, only revealing its existence to them at the end of his life, and then selecting one of them to inherit it. And now I'm continuing the family tradition." "But you're not at the end of your life," said Felipe, who was more interested in his father's longevity than the nugget. Ricardo laughed. "I'm eighty-six and I feel the decline. I'm at peace with my inevitable death but it's important to me that my affairs be in order." "We could have been rich," said Carlos, angrily. "You could have sold this nugget and given us everything we wanted. Instead, we lived in relative poverty and had to work for everything we got." "And this is what your great-great-great-great-grandfather wanted," said Ricardo, "for his descendants to find their own way in life and use this nugget only when in desperate need. We were never in desperate need. We had our health, our faculties, a home, and family." Carlos shook his head in disgust. "So who gets the nugget then, me or him?" He sneered while indicating his brother. The two of them had been inseparable as children but Carlos rarely spoke to him anymore. "Whoever deserves it the most," said Ricardo. "I gave you both the same start in life. Now I want to know which one of you has lived a better life." Carlos laughed. "Do we really need to discuss this?" Both he and Felipe had followed their father into the construction

industry. However, while Felipe had remained a modestly-paid employee, Carlos had started his own company. "While my brother was working nine to five, I was working a hundred hours a week. I bought my first house when I was twenty-six and now I live in a villa in Malibu, and drive a Mercedes Benz." Carlos knew he needed the nugget less than his brother did but he deserved it more. He was certain of that. "And you, Felipe," said Ricardo. "Do you think you have lived a better life than your brother?" "Absolutely," said Felipe.

Fiction

A Short Story: Hot Cakes Non si paga solo il prodotto: si paga l'esperienza. È questa la conclusione a cui è arrivata la protagonista di questa storia dopo aver provato i migliori scone della città. Rachel Roberts, Rachel Roberts Carlos snorted, but Ricardo silenced him and Felipe continued. "While Carlos was working a hundred hours a week, I was going home every evening and preparing dinner for my wife and children. While he was working every weekend, I was creating memories with them, visiting the beaches and forests and mountains and deserts of California, hiking, biking, and camping. We never had much money but what we had — what we have — is more precious than anything money can buy. Carlos sacrificed his life for money. I sacrificed the pursuit of money for a life of value." "My life has value too," said Carlos, defensively. "I live in a villa in Malibu. I drive a Mercedes Benz. I have an investment portfolio. I could buy everything you have with the money I make in a month." "But you can't really buy what I have," said Felipe. "You can't buy love. While you were working your life away, your wife left you for another man and your children became estranged from you. What do you have now? What do you really have?" "I have... I have everything I want..." "And nothing you really need," said Felipe gently. "I want a better life for you, brother. I want you to have the life we had as children, a life of love and laughter and friendship and community." "But I... I... I..." Carlos tried to argue but instead he started to cry. His brother was right, and he knew it. He didn't have anything of real value anymore. Felipe embraced him. "Come home to us," he said, "be part of our family again." "Okay," said Carlos, his voice barely audible. Ricardo smiled in satisfaction. By using the golden nugget to convince Carlos to come home, he had used it as his great-great-great-grandfather had intended it to be used: to help a

family member in desperate need. He hoped that when the time came, Felipe or his descendants would do the same.

Glossary

- **shook** = scuotere
- **in disgust** = con disgusto
- **deserves** = meritare
- **hiking** = fare trekking, fare escursionismo
- **pursuit** = ricerca
- **became estranged** = allontanarsi, diventare estranei
- **precious** = prezioso
- **working your life away** = passare la vita a lavorare
- **gently** = dolcemente
- **great-great-great-great-grandfather** = quintavolo
- **sneered** = sogghignare
- **snorted** = sbuffare
- **golden nugget** = pepita d'oro
- **attest to** = attestare, dare testimonianza di
- **heirs** = eredi
- **I gave you both the same start in life** = ho dato a entrambi le stesse opportunità nella vita
- **certain** = sicuro
- **barely** = appena
- **inherit** = ereditare